That same Chola prince Elara (or Ellalan) mentioned above is also celebrated in Tamil folklore as Manu needi Cholan, ‘The Chola who followed Manu (the Lawgiver)’. The story goes that as ruler of Lanka he installed a bell outside his courtroom which anyone seeking justice could ring. One day the bell was rung by a cow, and on enquiry it was discovered that the king’s son had accidentally driven over the cow’s calf in his chariot. In the interests of justice the king then killed his son under the wheels of his own chariot. But how should one interpret such a horrifying tale – as an example of extreme piety or of religious fanaticism? To me it suggests the beginnings of Brahminical influence at the court of a Chola ruler early in the second century BCE, since the Jains and the Buddhists were as much against cow-slaughter as the Hindus, but as pacifists were also opposed to all forms of violence.

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The identification of Emperor Ashoka and his edicts was the result of what must surely rate as Indian historiography’s single most important breakthrough: the deciphering of the Brahmi alphabet by the Calcutta-based director of the Bengal mint James Prinsep in 1837, which not only opened the door for every early text to be read but also restored Emperor Ashoka to Indian history. Scarcely less important, to my mind, was the formation of the Archaeological Survey of India (ASI) and the appointment in 1861 of General Sir Alexander Cunningham as its first director. However, Cunningham’s brief never extended to South India. Here the first official archaeologist was a Scots educationalist named James Burgess, who in 1871 was appointed head of the new Archaeological Survey, Western India. After Cunningham’s retirement in 1886 Burgess stepped into his shoes, so that for the first time the whole of British India came under the authority of one archaeological body.